What leaders propose, the gods of democracy, the voters, dispose in their own way. For Narendra Modi, the crowning glory of his being prime minister for a decade was to be the induction into a rarefied league of statesmen in 2024. For that, he had to emulate the record held by Jawaharlal Nehru, India's first prime minister, who had three consecutive terms with a full majority in Parliament. Modi intended to achieve the distinction with a thumping mandate in the general election. The year began auspiciously enough, when as *yajmaan* (patron) he led the consecration ceremony of the Balak Ram idol at the new and awe-inspiring Ram Mandir in Ayodhya on January 22. The event was regarded as a spectacular demonstration of Hindu resurgence and pride. Modi captured the zeitgeist when he began his evocative address by saying, "Our Ram Lalla will no longer be living in a tent, he will now reside in his divine mandir."

The material culmination of a century-old struggle to build the mandir and the deep emotional valence it held for India's Hindu majority was considered a game-changer for the Lok Sabha polls. So much so, Modi set a high benchmark for his Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners with the war cry, *'Ab ki Baar, Chaar Sau Paar* (This time, 400 seats-plus)'. The confidence stemmed from the BJP's belief that it had dealt a body blow to the Opposition INDIA bloc early in 2024 by winning over Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar, its prime mover. The other trump card was the BJP wresting power in Maharashtra in 2022 after it engineered a split in the Shiv Sena, and later the Nationalist Congress Party, in this crucial state.

However, when the general election results came out, it was far below expectations. The BJP's tally dropped from 303 seats to 240—32 short of a simple majority in the Lok Sabha—and it needed the support of its NDA partners, especially Nitish's Janata Dal (United) in Bihar and Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party in Andhra Pradesh, to form the government. Modi did make history as prime minister for an incredible third consecutive term but the fact that the INDIA bloc had considerably diminished the BJP's dominance robbed the occasion of its sheen. Modi had to evolve a new coalition dharma, with its own compulsions, complexities and contradictions. This was most evident when he tried to ram through the 'One Nation, One Poll' idea, but without the requisite support in the House had to send it to a joint parliamentary committee for review.

There were lessons to be learnt for both Modi and the BJP from the outcome. Especially that aggressive Hindutva mixed with a large dole of welfare measures had diminishing returns with an electorate now wanting jobs and respite from high prices. They still trusted Modi to deliver but the seams of their support were beginning to wear thin. Unlike the cocky INDIA bloc, Modi and the BJP heeded these warnings and ensured they won two crucial assembly poll victories in Haryana and Maharashtra to regain the political momentum. These wins were clearly a mandate for Modi 3.0 to pursue the critical reforms needed, especially on the economic front in 2025.

The politics of the economy would guide Modi's governance decisions in 2024 too. To address concerns of rising joblessness, the prime minister resorted to bold and unconventional measures. In July, for Budget 2024, Modi got Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman to announce a massive scheme

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to facilitate employment and skilling for 41 million youngsters in private companies with an allocation of Rs 2 lakh crore over five years. With private investments remaining sluggish, Modi decided to sustain public spending on infrastructure development by allotting Rs 11.1 lakh crore, or 3.4 per cent of the GDP in the budget, in the hope that it would stimulate economic growth and provide additional jobs. For the private sector, Modi pushed for greater research and innovation with a financing pool of Rs 1 lakh crore.

In his Independence Day speech, his eleventh and longest so far, Modi talked extensively about the Ease of Living Mission and gave assurances of massive improvements in infrastructure in urban areas. That perhaps was an effort to woo the middle-classes who felt neglected by the welfare measures doled out for the poor. Modi's other major commitment was to make India a global manufacturing hub to reduce dependency on imports, a cornerstone of which was becoming a world leader in semiconductor production to enhance technological self-sufficiency. These initiatives set the agenda for Modi 3.0 but the Indian economy remained a work in progress throughout 2024,